



Vital experience: Tejaswin Shankar competed for Kansas State University between 2017 and 2021. He now helps Indian athletes manage their recruitment process, while directly coordinating with coaches in the USA. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Calvert, who was his coach at the time, suggested I try to go to the USA. He helped me out with emails and contacts, and that's how my journey started," he says.

Tejaswin's experiences of simply emailing prospective coaches are mirrored by some of the other Indians who have made their own path to the USA. Arjanvir is one of them. Growing up in New Delhi, he had reached a level of success in the Indian domestic system — making the final of the 400m at the U20 national championships in 2021.

Arjanvir says he had friends and family who had played collegiate tennis and squash in the USA and went to them for advice on how to apply himself. "I was privileged in a way because I had the knowledge of how something like this was possible. I have been preparing for this path ever since I was in class 10. I took their advice and started reaching out to coaches. I sent a bunch of emails in which I introduced myself, mentioned my current timing and that I wanted to study in the USA and run at the same time. It was like

sending out resumes for an internship.

"I must have emailed about 200 coaches, of whom about 100 responded. About 50 got on a call with me and about 25 got on a second call. I actually had a few colleges to choose from, and out of those, I finally decided to go with Wagner because I had a cousin who had already played tennis over here," says Arjanvir.

While he had the advantage of knowing sportspeople who had made the journey before him, most